# CHAPTER 8 Global Hip Hop: Style, Language, and Globalization

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## Introduction

The last fifteen years or so have seen the emergence of an international body of literature in "Hip Hop Linguistics," or "HHLx" (Alim 2006), comprising many rich and varied linguistic practices of Hip Hop communities "from Brooklyn to Baghdad" collectively representing the originality and complexity, the dynamism and diversity, and the power, politics, pleasure, and potential of youth linguistic creativity (Alim 2006, p. 7). Linguists researching Hip Hop Culture have enlivened scholarship on language through in-depth analyses and critical reframings of key concepts in linguistic anthropology. At the same time, these scholars have also enhanced Hip Hop Studies by foregrounding language use and linguistic structure in their analyses of Hip Hop cultural practice, thereby adding a layer of empirical studies to an area of inquiry dominated by cultural studies and humanistic approaches.

This chapter reviews key issues in the study of style, language, Hip Hop Culture, and globalization and concludes by offering some implications for a linguistic anthropology of globalization. Critically synthesizing a wide range of recent work on Hip Hop, I present an empirical account of *youth as cultural theorists*. In doing so, I bring together the insights of *hiphopography*—a paradigm in Hip Hop Studies that integrates the varied approaches of ethnography, biography, and social, cultural, and oral history (Spady et al. 2006)—with key issues in linguistic anthropology. With their ideas, Hip Hop youth help us make sense not only of one of the most important linguistic movements of the late twentieth and early twenty-first centuries but also of broader cultural changes across contemporary societies. For this reason, I frame my discussion in the context of shifts in the study of language brought upon by a world increasingly characterized by transnationalism, immigration, hybridity, diaspora, and fluidity.

In response to these shifts, several fundamental, taken for granted concepts in linguistic anthropology have come under increasing scrutiny. For example, one key concept that has

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undergone drastic revision is the notion of "local speech community." As noted by Ben Rampton (1998) and Michael Silverstein (1998), *speech community* (Gumperz 1968, p. 381)—"any human aggregate characterized by regular and frequent interaction by means of a shared body of verbal signs and set off from similar aggregates by significant differences in language usage"—has always been a troubled term (see Suzanne Romaine (1982) for an earlier critique), mired in a number of methodological, theoretical, and political debates. A key study in this area by Debra Spitulnik (1996) addressed the social circulation of media discourse in Zambian society and introduced several new ways of thinking about speech communities in mass-mediated, technologically connected, large-scale societies. Marcyliena Morgan (2004, p. 3) has noted that the concept of speech community needs reworking in situations marked by "change, diversity, and increasing technology." For a global level of analysis, we can think in terms of translocal style communities, which can be discussed from the point of view of the transportability of *mobile matrices*—sets of styles, aesthetics, knowledges, and ideologies that travel across localities and cross-cut modalities. These communities are built on both stylistic commonalities and differences and can be analyzed to explore the repeated stylizations involved in Global Hip Hop Culture(s) (Alim 2009). This line of research builds upon Alastair Pennycook's (2006 p. 73) call for an "anti-foundationalist" view of language, one that views language as a product of repeated stylizations rather than a predetermined object of analysis.

Another concept that has been the focus of much debate has been that of *style* or *stylization* (Rampton 1999, 2006; Eckert and Rickford 2002; Alim 2004a; Coupland 2007; Mendoza-Denton 2008). The growing consensus on the fluidity of identities and focus on stylization developed, in part, because identities were being theorized in a world witnessing a proliferation of non-regionalized virtual places and increasingly decentralized authority (Meyrowitz 1986). Recent work on stylization and Hip Hop Culture(s) supports Rampton's (1999, p. 423) perspective on style by problematizing "*production within* particular cultural spaces" and instead looking at "*projection-across*," at speech's "transposition into and out of arenas where social conditions and social relations are substantially different" (original emphasis).

Globalization has created multiple new opportunities for youth to reinvent identities through the remixing of styles which are now, as a result of a multitude of technological innovations, more globally available than ever before. Following Jan Blommaert's (2003) call for a much-needed "sociolinguistics of globalization," the chapter concludes with some ideas about a linguistic anthropology of globalization characterized by comparative, multi-sited ethnographic explorations and a theoretical focus on popular culture, music, and mass-mediated language as central to linguistic processes. This linguistic anthropology of globalization explores youths' fundamentally agentive act of theorizing the changes in the contemporary world as they attempt to locate themselves at the intersections of the local and the global.

## Global Hip Hop Culture(s) and Style(s)

As Pennycook (2007) pointed out in his in-depth exploration of the relationship between Global Englishes and Hip Hop's "transcultural flows," Hip Hop Cultures may in fact be one of the most important sources for the study of globalization, not only because Hip Hop has reached far corners of the globe but also because it is a mass-mediated popular cultural form that relies heavily on the use of language and technology even as it radically transforms them. Below I address a related and significant set of questions: How did Hip

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Hop Culture become a primary site of identification and self-understanding for youth around the world? And even more specifically, what stylistic resources do youth manipulate, (re)appropriate, and sometimes (re)create, in order to fashion themselves as members of a Global Hip Hop Nation? How do these youth, through their use of multiple styles and language varieties, negotiate their membership within this "nation" as they index the multiplicities of their identities? Finally, and most importantly, how have explorations of these questions about the globalization of Hip Hop Culture led to the reworking of major concepts in the study of language (including language itself) and to a centering of popular cultural and mass-mediated forms of language use?

Youth all around the world have engaged Hip Hop, creating their own versions of Hip Hop Nation Language Varieties (HHNL and HHNLVs, see below) and communicating with one another through the prism of style to form a *global style community*. Although global style communities may indeed grow out of particular sociohistoric originating moments, or moments in which cultural agents take on the project of creating "an origin" (in this case, Afrodiasporic youth in the United States in the 1970s), it is important to note that a global style community is far from a threatening, homogenizing force (Appadurai 1996; Blommaert 2003; Pennycook 2003). For Arjun Appadurai, unlike previous center-periphery models, the global situation is constructed of multiple, interactive nodes. This suggests that a global style community such as the Global Hip Hop Nation is better thought of as a network of overlapping and intersecting translocal style communities, with members in particular localities "making a choice to be connected across recognized boundaries" (Cooke and Lawrence 2006, p. 1). This persistent dialectical interplay between the local and the global gives rise to the creative linguistic styles that are central to the formation of translocal style communities.

## Glocal Stylizations and Style as Glocal Distinctiveness

James G. Spady (1991, pp. 223–225) was one of the earliest scholars to comment on Black American Hip Hop's global influence: "Hip Hop Culture, that irresistibly dynamic and alluring Black American expressive form, is rapidly juicing the world … Styling and Profiling … [Hip Hop artists] are bringing about a revolution in dress, talk, song, dance and nonverbal discourse [and] they are in the enviable position of influencing international values, trends, and styles." Spady's comments allude to "style" and "Styling and Profiling" in the Black American tradition and their global spread, as well as the multimodality of Hip Hop style through embodied verbal and nonverbal modes of communication.

Style is central to Hip Hop Culture(s) as an overarching, ideologically mediated and motivated aesthetic system of distinction (Irvine 2001). In cultural studies, the most notable work in this area is by Dick Hebdige (1979), who highlights several uses of style by youth, most notably as resistance to subordination. In her work on Hip Hop, Tricia Rose (1994, pp. 37–38) productively draws on Hebdige, arguing that Hip Hop artists use style for alternative status formation, "forging local identities for teenagers who understand their limited access to traditional avenues of social status attainment." She continues, quoting US Hip Hop MC and graffiti artist Fab Five Freddy on the relationship between style, identity, and local status in Hip Hop: "You make a new style. That's what life on the street is all about. What's at stake is honor and position on the street. That's what makes it so important, that's what makes it feel so good—that pressure on you to be the best. Or try to be the best. To develop a new style nobody can deal with" (quoted in Rose 1994, p. 38).

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We can theorize style not simply by reading cultural texts but by taking the cultural theories of the stylists themselves as important points of departure (Muggleton 2000). This approach is exemplified by the "hiphopographies" collected by researchers at Philadelphia's Black History Museum (Spady et al. 1999, 2006, 1995; Spady and Eure 1991). For example, in their interview with bicoastal US Hip Hop artist Kurupt, Spady et al. (1999) provide a deep sense of rappers' personal investment in style. Below, Kurupt explains that he learned his rhyming skills as a young boy in the East Coast ciphas (or competitive and communal rhyme circles; see Alim 2006) of Philly:

> Back in the day, I was like thirteen. A circle of ten or twelve people, ages of like thirteen and below, one might have been twenty, twenty-one. And when it came down to the last two [rhymers], I was always there. And I've always been number one. Always. I never lost them type battles. You bust and it's like you don't say the next person's name, and you're out of there. I've always been in there. I just sit back and bust rhymes and I used to spell things on people's shirts. Like he'd have a shirt that says "Walk" on it. I'd break it down like the "W" is for this, the "A" is for that, the "L" is for this, and the "K" is for that. And they be like, "What?!" **That's my style. Nobody else was doing that. That's something I created** … Like, he could have a soda can, "Pepsi." Once, I spelled Pepsi for this nigga. "The 'P' is for punctuating rhymes and woo-woo-woo. 'E' is for executing." And they're like, "God!" And I'm like what – thirteen, fourteen. C'mon now. They called me "The Kid." That was my rappin name because I was the youngest nigga that would always make it into the cipha. (quoted in Spady et al. 1999, p. 539)

For Black American Hip Hop artists, and in Black American cultural practice more generally, style, as expressed through the creation and invention of new, fresh, original, and innovative productions, is critical to the artists' reception. Further, in addition to style as distinctiveness (Irvine 2001), Kurupt's comments also frame style as competitiveness: "And when it came down to the last two [rhymers], I was always there. And I've always been number one. Always. I never lost them type battles." Or as Wu-Tang Clan member Raekwon demonstrated, responding to an interview question about what makes a "dope MC," style can be framed as originality: "Style, you know what I mean, you just gotta be original. You gotta be able to say things, you know, automatically that people don't normally say. You gotta design your own flow, you know what I mean? Because it's so many people out there with different type of flows, but if you make your own flow up, that makes you more original and makes you one of the more outstanding MCs" (unpublished interview, Alim 2001).

The above examples demonstrate the centrality of style in Hip Hop and its function as a system of distinction, driven by a nearly obsessive desire to be "original," "creative," or simply "the best." In Spady et al. (2006) *Tha Global Cipha: Hip Hop Culture and Consciousness*, the word *style* appears 260 times in the 700-page tome, which covers a wide range of interviews with artists from the United States, Africa, Europe, and the Caribbean. Crucially, style appears to be equally prominent in discussions with MCs, DJs, dancers, and graffiti artists. Style in Hip Hop, as Judith Irvine (2001, p. 23) notes regarding subcultural style in general, cuts across "communicative and behavioral modalities," and importantly, "integrates them thematically." It is primarily for this reason that I have argued for style as the central rubric through which to read Hip Hop Cultures. Further, my use of *style* extends what Marco Jacquemet (2005, p. 264) refers to as *transidiomatic practices* to describe "the communicative practices of transnational groups that interact using different languages and communicative codes simultaneously present in a range of communicative channels, both local and distant." As previously noted, style allows us to integrate such insights and expand them to work at a level beyond linguistic structure.

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In this globalizing era of rapid technologically mediated communication, style is relevant to the gaining of local status (as in Rose 1994, above); serves as a system of distinction and aesthetics organized around locally relevant principles of value (as in Irvine 2001); is the property of local speech communities or locally situated communities of practice (as in much of the sociolinguistic and linguistic-anthropological literature). We can also view style, as theorized by global Hip Hop youth, as *glocal distinctiveness*, where members of the Global Hip Hop Nation put style to use in order to distinguish themselves from adherents to other possible styles in their local arenas as well as to simultaneously contrast with and connect themselves to a global network of practitioners, each claiming their "own style" (or what US rapper KRS-One [1996, p. 60] refers to as a "my-style" and a "your-style"). Importantly, as Irvine (2001, p. 21) notes, "though [style] may characterize an individual, it does so only within a social framework (of witnesses who pay attention)" and "it thus depends on social evaluation" and "it interacts with idealized representations."

## Stylistic (Re)mixing

In the case of the glocal stylizations found in Global Hip Hop Cultures, local styles interact dialectically with the idealized representation of Black American HHNLVs (the whole range of possibilities in an approach to language that is as contingent upon Black America's continued role as a dominant frame of reference as it is on local approaches to language) and various other possible styles, drawing on each other's semiotic resources in a process of "semiotic reconstruction" (Pennycook 2003, p. 527, citing Kandiah 1998, p. 100). This stylistic (re)mixing, as many have pointed out, goes well beyond mere imitation. The radical recontextualizations and creative uses to which semiotic resources are put signal an era of "global linguistic flows" (Alim et al. 2009) in which linguistic and other semiotic material circulates around the world's "langscapes" (cf. Appadurai 1996; Blommart 2003; Pennycook 2003) to produce not global languages that function via shared linguistic norms, but, rather, global and translocal style communities operating on stylistic commonalities and contrasts that pay equal attention to the local and the global.

Black American Hip Hop artist Raekwon's interactions with multiple communities, from "the streets" of the United States to the *banlieues* of Black-Beur France, illustrate these non-language-bound concepts of global and translocal style communities. A member of the mighty Wu-Tang Clan, Raekwon hails from Shaolin, also known as Staten Island, New York, and specifically the Park Hill neighborhood. Like other Wu affiliates, he's known for rappin in a distinct Shaolin, New York, East Coast style that highlights clever word and sound play, esoteric slang, and ample use of the Five Percent Nation of Islam's Supreme Alphabet and Supreme Mathematics (Miyakawa 2005). In addition to this local level of stylistic distinction, he is also in dialogue with various global Hip Hop artists. As Morgan (2004, p. 6) has pointed out, membership in the Global Hip Hop Nation is "partially constructed through transnationalism, technology, music, and politically and socially marginalized youth." Raekwon's collaboration with Black French artist Ol Kainry, "*De* Park Hill *à 91 Pise*" (2004), provides a perfect example of this and highlights the level of communication that is at work here, one that is not constrained by any one particular linguistic system.

In the video for "*De* Park Hill *à 91 Pise*," Ol Kainry and Raekwon trade verses in a mixture of English, French, *verlan* (a French youth register where words are encoded by reversing syllables and by changes in spelling), Black Language (also known as Ebonics or African American Vernacular English), and their respective HHNLVs. They rhyme in a

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studio, set against a moving backdrop of their local hoods (Park Hill and 91 Pise), with their lyrics inscribed on and circling the concrete buildings and streets of the Shaolin housing projects and throughout New York City. In this first verse, Raekwon rhymes while Ol Kainry interjects:

> **Raekwon**: *Hey yo, hey yo, hey yo*, drugs get *served* when it's nighttime / Bodies get found **[Ol Kainry: Mm-hmm]** / So many young niggaz gettin lifetime/ Don't know nu'in but the *scrape up* / That's France, shit, **[Ol Kainry: Word!]** / in other words, *sun, get yo cake up…*

Here, Raekwon begins his flow with the classically Shaolin phrase, *Hey yo, hey yo, hey yo* and then uses a stream of esoteric and encoded HHNL to highlight the connective marginalities (Osumare 2008) in both rappers' local hoods. His narrative depicts drug-dealing ("drugs get served") and its consequences—death ("bodies get found") or life in prison ("so many young niggaz gettin lifetime")—and a generation of youth who have no other option but to participate in the informal economy ("don't know nu'in but the *scrape up*"). He closes by addressing the young men in that situation as *sun* (which doubles for *son*, as well as the Five Percenter term for "male"[1]), and offers an empathetic word of compassion that acknowledges one's right to do what is advantageous for oneself ("get yo cake up"). All the while, Ol Kainry interjects with stock phrases from Black American HHNL, such as *Word!* which also stems from the language of the Five Percenter community in the United States.

Ol Kainry, whose name is in fact *verlan* for 'Old American',[2] both sees himself and is viewed by audiences in France as having an "American" style. Throughout, he interjects phrases like *Word!* and *Hey, yo!* and rhymes whole lines that complicate any notion of discrete languages. For example, he begins the last verse like this: "Yo, *mon* mic *est un flingue pour mon* hood *un* bad *clin d'oeil*" [Yo, my mic is a gun / and much respect to my hood (or "for my hood, a bad shout-out"), pointing out how his "mic" serves as a weapon for his "hood." Further, his use of *bad* here follows Black American semantic inversion to mean something positive, as Run DMC pointed out over two decades ago in "Peter Piper" (1986), "not bad meaning *BAD*, but bad meaning *GOOD*!"

In this second example, the two rappers exchange lines in the hook, and we see some more verbal play:

> RAEKWON: Me and Ol Kainry explain /
> OL KAINRY: *De Park Hill à 91 Pise, les scarlas s'tchekent* ('From Park Hill to 91 Pise, gangstas link up') / Ice Water Inc., Ol Kainry, Raekwon the Chef /
> RAEKWON: From Park Hill to 91 Pise, gangstas link up / Ice Water Inc. and Ol' Kainry / We all thinkers…

In the above example, Ol Kainry employs *verlan* when he spits "*les scarlas*", which is an inversion of the syllables in the French term *lascars*, meaning 'gangsta' or 'thug'. Additionally, he employs a Black American term, *check* (in French spelling, *tchek*), as in "Yo, I'ma go check my man" i.e., 'I'm going to go see how my friend is doing,' and recontextualizes it,

[1] In the Five Percent Nation of Islam, the sun represents man. The moon represents woman. The stars represent children. The Five Percent Nation of Islam (The Nation of Gods and Earths) was founded in Harlem in the 1960s and practices an indigenous form of Islam in the US.

[2] Ol Kainry adopts a Black American naming practice in Hip Hop, as seen in the Wu-Tang Clan's Ol Dirty Bastard (there's no father to his *style*, he claims!), but uses the French youth register of *verlan* in which *Américain* ('American') is shortened to *ricain* and then the syllables are reversed and the spelling changed to yield *Kainry*.

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submerging the term in a French HHNLV that incorporates *verlan*, French, and Black American HHNL.

As mentioned above, Hip Hop style does not impose a homogenized "one-world" culture upon its practitioners. Through Raekwon's use of Black Language and a Park Hill HHNLV and Ol Kainry's use of the French youth register *verlan* and the 91 Pise Hip Hop HHNLV—their respective "resistance vernaculars" (Potter 1995)—membership in the global style community of Hip Hop is negotiated not through a particular language, but through particular styles of language, and these styles are ideologically mediated and motivated in that their use allows for a shared respect based on representing one's particular locality. A global style community is one that is not located geographically or even linguistically, as we have seen; rather, membership may have to do with language ideologies and transidiomatic practices as much as with shared linguistic systems and local norms (cf. Morgan 2004).

The notion of global and translocal style communities is more complex still. Despite the all too available metaphor of Hip Hop as a universal language, style in global and translocal style communities is hotly contested, as it is often a critical measure of one's artistic self-worth and a litmus test of one's authenticity in a community where, as Raekwon raps above, "we all thinkers." Previous research (Alim et al. 2009) has examined these tensions around moments of identification with local and global aspects of Hip Hop. Below, I reframe the HHNL model in relation to issues of globalization.

## Mobile Matrices and the Remixing of Hip Hop Nation Language Varieties

A preoccupation with style and stylization and their links to identity and identification is found in nearly every locale where Hip Hop is practiced. In Italy, for example, style emerges as central in rapper Neffa's rhyme *Dimmi com'è che Snefs stila 'sti stili* ('Tell me why Snefs styles these styles') (cited in Androutsopoulos and Scholz 2003, p. 475); in Japan, in Hip Hop group Rip Slime's song "Yo, Bringing That, Yo Bring Your Style" (cited in Pennycook 2006, p. 96); in Senegal, Positive Black Soul discusses style at length in a conversation that itself is loaded with African American stylizations (Spady et al. 2006, pp. 639–655); and in Nigeria, in Hip Hop artist 2-Shotz's commitment "to do *am Naija* style" [to do it Nigerian style] (cited in Omoniyi 2008).

In the Philippines, Hip Hop group GHOST 13 (Guys Have Own Style to Talk; cited in Pennycook 2006, pp. 130–131) explicitly makes the link between stylization and their linguistic and cultural identities when they claim: "Listen everyone we are the only one rap group in the land who represent zamboanga man! / Guyz have own style, style to talk a while di kami mga wanna ['we are not imitators'] because we have own identity."[3] As this example illustrates, issues of locality, authenticity, and style as glocal distinctiveness abound in global Hip Hop Cultures.

In theorizing globalization, a focus on style in Hip Hop Cultures allows us not only to highlight the role of aesthetics, but also to put some empirical clothes (baggy jeans and a white tee perhaps) on Appadurai's theoretical hanger, which gives us a promising vision of cultural globalization but no sense of its workings. Hip Hop is an example of what I have referred to as *mobile matrices*, where sets of styles, practices, ideologies, knowledges,

[3] According to Pennycook (2007, p. 130), Zamboangueño is the most widely spoken of a number of Spanish-based creoles in the Philippines. Chavacano is the general term for these creoles and is derived from the Spanish *chabacano* ('vulgar'). In line with Hip Hop's language politics, the marginalized Chavacano is celebrated by GHOST 13.

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and aesthetics travel together across the globe—*globe-hip-hopping*, if you will[4]—and are necessarily engaged with as a unit (but taken up partially and differentially) across a wide range of contexts (Alim 2009). Like Pennycook and Mitchell (2009), I am not arguing that some hegemonic form of Hip Hop moves wholesale around the global market and creates other Hip Hops in its own image and likeness. Rather, I would like to draw our attention to how Hip Hop youth theorize the differential adoption/adaptation of the styles, practices, ideologies, knowledges, and aesthetics that necessarily must be engaged (sometimes by mere imitation, sometimes by outright rejection, but oftentimes by creative reworking) when entering the Hip Hop matrix.

Though not using these terms, Richardson's (2006, p. 65) discussion of respect and Pennycook's 2006, p. 14) discussion of authenticity in Hip Hop Culture are helpful in elucidating what I mean by Hip Hop's mobile matrix. Richardson describes how German Hip Hoppers were introduced to Black American ideologies of respect and adopted them in their online practice. In addition, Pennycook highlights the "constant tension" between the global spread of authenticity in Hip Hop, "a culture of being true to the local, of telling it like it is" and "the constant pull towards localization that this implies." All over the world, he argues, there is a "compulsion to not only make Hip Hop locally relevant but also to define locally what authenticity means." Viewing Hip Hop as a mobile matrix suggests that there are at least two levels of meaning working simultaneously in Hip Hop's globalization: the imperative to identify with global Hip Hop (with Black America as a dominant frame of reference for many contexts) and the imperative to create something that pushes local boundaries and distinguishes oneself from both local and global Hip Hop styles (mediated by a demanding and competitive ideology of style).

Turning specifically to language, I reframe my working notion of HHNL and HHNLVs (Alim 2004b, 2006) in relation to this concept of Hip Hop as a mobile matrix. In brief, in that work I described HHNL as a language variety that relies heavily on the African aspect of Black American uses of English; this characterization leans on Kamau Brathwaite's (1984, p. 13) description of "nation languages" in the Caribbean: "English it may be in terms of some of its lexical features. But in its contours, its rhythm and timbre, its sound explosions, it is not English." As articulated in Hip Hop youths' theorizing, *language* refers not only to internal, structural qualities but also to the many discursive and communicative practices (*call and response*, *battling and freestylin in tha cipha*, *multilayered totalizing expression*, *poetics and flow*, etc.), language ideologies (often counterhegemonic), understandings of the role of language in both binding/bonding community and seizing/smothering linguistic opponents, and "language as concept" (having to do with broader forms of semiotic expression), including clothing styles, facial expressions, dance styles and body movements, graffiti styles, and so on (see further Alim 2006, p. 71).

Further, in that earlier work I outlined ten tenets of HHNL, which collectively recognized the importance of style and aesthetics, language ideologies and processes of identification, and the sociopolitical contexts of language use in Hip Hop, as well as both the regionalization of HHNL in the US and the globalization of HHNL Varieties around the world. Specifically, I noted that HHNL "is widely spoken across the country, and used/borrowed and adapted/transformed by various ethnic groups inside and outside the US" (Alim 2004b, p. 394). In this chapter, I continue to describe the use of language in diverse Hip

[4] *Globe-hip-hopping* is a play on Ferguson's (2006, p. 38) term *globe-hopping*, which he uses to emphasize the point that the "movement of capital" does not "cover the globe" but rather "connects discrete points on it." The Hip Hop matrix travels and circulates in a similar manner, but I do not mean to suggest that it covers the world like a global blanket. Rather, it globe-hip-hops through various hoods.

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Hop locales as *Hip Hop Nation Language Varieties*. Rather than the normative use of *Hip Hop Nation Language* to refer specifically to the language of Black American Hip Hop and its remixes, it is preferable to use the global term *Hip Hop Nation Language Varieties* to refer to the use of language in and across specific Hip Hop localities (including the US). For some scholars, the language remixes involved in the creation of global Hip Hops cause us to remix the very notion of language.

## Linguistic Remixing and Agentive Languaging

Looking more closely at linguistic structure, HHNLVs abound with examples of linguistic remixing, giving us yet another reason to put "language" in quotation marks. Above, I described a view of language from within Hip Hop that stresses far more than linguistic structure and internal characteristics. Beyond this, the use of language in global Hip Hop Cultures causes us to de-essentialize languages in the same way that we have de-essentialized identity categories such as race and gender in postmodernity. Several examples serve to make the point.

Haitian, Dominican, and African rappers in the complex multiethnic and multilingual Hip Hop communities in Canada view their linguistic remixes as community-building practices, enabling translinguistic communication through the production of Hip Hop style. As Haitian-Canadian rapper Impossible states in an interview with Mela Sarkar and Dawn Allen (2007) regarding style and locality in *le style montrealais*: "I'd define the Montreal style as, it's the only place where you have a cultural mix like that, where you have a mixture of languages like that, whether it's English, [Haitian] Creole, then French, but all the same a Quebec French" (Sarkar and Allen 2007, p. 122). The authors show that, through continual linguistic borrowing, Montreal youth involved in Hip Hop carve out a place for themselves in the public sphere while creating a community "based on a mixture of French and English as a common language, but with an ever-present and constantly changing admixture of words and phrases from other sources as its defining feature." Sarkar and Allen note that in the midst of all of this multilingualism, and even in Quebec where the most widely used language in Hip Hop is French, not English, Hip Hop artists use aspects of African American English (AAE) in their lyrics and everyday speech (2007, p. 120).

Black American HHNLVs are remixed in numerous scenes around the world, as evidenced in global Hip Hop naming practices like the names of Tanzanian artists "Nigga J," "Ice II," and "G.W.M. Gangstas with Matatizo" (cited in Perullo and Fenn 2003, pp. 23–24) and German record companies "Yo Mama" and "Put da needle to da groove," or European remixes of Black American rhetorical formulae like "Snoop Doggy Dogg is in the house" (X *ist im Saal* in German; X *(est) dans la place* in French; and X *(está) en la casa* in Spanish): all cited in (Androutsopoulos and Scholz 2003, p. 474). Also relevant are the practices of battlin and freestylin in Australia (Maxwell 2003); Japan (Condry 2006); in Nigeria (Omoniyi et al. 2008); and South Africa (Williams 2017). In Tanzania, several scholars have written about the mixing of Black American HHNLVs with Swahili and other languages. As in the case of Oxmo Puccino in France (previously discussed), both Remes (1998) and Perullo and Fenn (2003) discuss Tanzanian Hip Hop artists studying Black American artists, imitating their flow and delivery, and even using similar names to carve out particular styles. Tanzanian artist Ice II, for example, states that he looked up to US rapper Ice-T and modeled his style after him (Perullo and Fenn 2003, p. 29), while Mr. II reports that he modeled himself after Tupac (an apparently ubiquitous Hip Hop icon in

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Tanzania) "sounding out the words until he had a sense of the rhyming and flow" (2003, p. 24).

But what does this self-described imitation mean for the supposed centrality of style in this global style community? If translocal style communities are about inventing a style "nobody can deal with," what are the implications of such imitations of Black American styles for our discussion? As we might have expected, Perullo and Fenn conclude, "even if rappers borrow from American rap icons," in the end, "they must still show that they are creative and have a *unique style of rapping*" (2003, p. 29, my emphasis). Higgins (2008), also working in Tanzania, shows us that this unique style of rapping is often done in multiple languages, such as Swahili, Kihuni (a sociolect spoken by self-ascribed *wahuni*, 'hooligans, gangsters'), and AAE, with Higgins focusing on the use of (African American) HHNL. In all of these works, we see that rappers flex various styles to convey a sense of multiple belongings and allegiances. Through various practices such as battles, rhyme ciphers, shout outs, and naming practices, and the use of Black American lexicon, phonology, and syntax, Black American HHNL is central to these youths' imagining themselves as both local and global agents in the world.

Linguistic remixing in Hip Hop is even more complex, as described in Pennycook's (2003, 2007) analyses of the language of Hip Hop Culture in Japan and Malaysia. Table 8.1, for example, is derived from Pennycook's discussion of three songs by Japanese Hip Hop group Rip Slime.

In his analysis of "Bring Your Style," Pennycook (2003, pp. 515–517) discusses the use of Black American HHNL (such as the globally present indexical *Yo!*) right alongside the Japanese *jinrui saigo no furiikiisaido* 'the last freaky side of the human race,' in what these youths call "freaky mixed Japanese." The Japanese lyric, however, is already mixed, with the first part of the phrase written in Japanese *kanji* and the second part written in both *katakana* (used generally for the transcription of non-Japanese words) and *hiragana* (used mainly for Japanese grammatical inflections). Further, as Pennycook explains, "in *furiikiisaido* we have a created, English-based word (*saido* [side] is commonly used, *furriikii* [freaky] less so)." This linguistic remixing presents us with important questions about the supposed one-to-one relationship between language and identity, between English for global purposes and Japanese for local purposes, and between "a language" and "a structure."

**Table 8.1** Lyrics by Japanese Hip Hop group Rip Slime (from Pennycook 2003, pp. 515–526); translation in boldface

| Lyrics | Transliteration and translation |
|---|---|
| Yo Bringing That, Yo Bring Your Style | *Yo Bringing that, Yo Bring your style* |
| 人類最後のフリーキーサイド | *Jinrui saigo no furikiisaido* |
| 'Bring Your Style' | **Yo Bringing That, Yo Bring Your Style** |
| | **The last freaky side of the human race** |
| By the Way Five Guy's Name (×3) | By the Way Five Guy's Name (×3) |
| Five Guy's Name is Rip Slyme 5′ | Five Guy's Name is Rip Slyme 5′ |
| 'By the Way' | |
| 錦糸町出 Freaky ダブルのJapanese | *Kinshichoo de freaky daburu no Japanese* |
| 'Tokyo Classic' | **Freaky mixed Japanese from Kinshichoo** |

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Rip Slime is clearly influenced by Black American HHNL. The group name itself builds upon the tradition of creative wordplay in that it exploits the sometimes globally marginalized *r/l* distinction in Japanese English to produce "Lips Rhyme" (Pennycook 2003, p. 530). But despite this global influence, the use of language by these artists is indexical of multiple cultural affiliations and identifications. As Pennycook concludes, Rip Slime's uses of multiple forms of Japanese, "Japanese which may locate these rappers as decidedly local (Kinshichoo) or which may signal their sense of cultural mixing," and multiple forms of English, which "at times explicitly echoes African American English while [at] other times seems more Japanese in its usage," avoids designations of local or global and appears to "flow itself across the boundaries of identity" (Pennycook 2003, p. 527). The multiplicity of indexicalities brought forth by such complex, multilayered uses of language demands an approach that gives a more central role to linguistic agency on the part of youth, as their remixes of the Hip Hop matrix indicate that these heteroglot language practices are central to their local/global understandings of self.

Pennycook (2007) reports similar cultural remixes elsewhere in Asia. In a Malaysian nightclub where Black American Hip Hop styles influence the various modes of Hip Hop stylizations, he discussed rap duo Too Phat (most certainly a carryover of US Hip Hop names such as *Too Short* and *Too Live Crew*, not to mention the word *phat*), comprised of Joe Flizzow and Malique.[5] Too Phat's rhyme demonstrates their simultaneously global and local orientation: "Hip Hop be connectin Kuala Lumpur with LB / Hip Hop be rockin up towns laced wit LV / Ain't necessary to roll in ice rimmed M3's and be blingin/Hip Hop be bringin together emcees."[6] Pennycook describes the Black American influences on pronunciation (consonant cluster reduction) and syntax (multiple uses of habitual *be*), but complicates the picture by noting that the rappers, "while locating themselves within the linguistic and cultural world of Hip Hop, which links across the globe yet operates as a cultural code, are also locating themselves in Malaysia and positioning themselves in particular ways in relation to Hip Hop Culture" (2003, p. 3). He goes on to show that other Too Phat lyrics make multiple references to Malaysian locales, foods, traditions, and the Muslim *fajr* prayer, and even potentially exclude a wider audience through the use of Malay mixed with Black American language: "Ya!!! Kau tertarik dengan liriks, baut lu terbalik / Mr. Malique, Joe Flizzow dan T-Bone spit it menarik … Pertama kali gilang gemilang ku rap Melayu" ("You are attracted to the lyrics, they make you feel good/Mr. Malique, Joe Flizzow and T-Bone spit it out cool … First time, just brilliant, I am rapping in Malay"). As Pennycook concludes, phrases like *spit it menarik* (Black American *spit it* means 'rap' and *menarik* means 'cool' in Malay) do not always have to be interpreted as cases of "styling the Other" (Rampton 1999). Rather, the use of various codes in the process of the simultaneously localizing and globalizing linguistic remixes in both Japan and Malaysia points to the need for an "anti-foundationalist" view of language, one that questions the status of separate languages as *a priori* given objects of analysis, de-essentializes language in the same way other social categories have been de-essentialized, and breaks down any isomorphic conception about the relationship between cultures and languages.

[5] *Flizzow* is based in the Black American practice of inserting the infix *izz* and means *Flow* (a central Hip Hop term). The practice is found in US rapper Jay Hova's song "Izzo (H.O.V.A.)", with lyrics "H to the izz-O, V to the izz-A," as well as in phrases like "Fo shizzle, my nizzle" ('For sure, my nigga').

[6] *LB* refers to Long Beach, California; *LV* refers to fashion designer Louis Vuitton; *Ice rimmed M3's* refers to a BMW automobile with flashy rims.

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## Hip Hop Youth Theorizing and a Linguistic Anthropology of Globalization

Hip Hop has helped linguistic anthropologists look beyond local communities and language as it is used in specific field sites and begin, through ethnographies of popular culture and mass-mediated language, to theorize a linguistic anthropology of globalization. Hip Hop artists manipulate, (re)appropriate, and sometimes (re)create stylistic resources through a process of stylistic remixing to construct themselves as members of the Global Hip Hop Nation. Following Pennycook (2007), the radical recontextualizations and (re) creative uses of stylistic and semiotic resources mark an era of "global linguistic flows" (Alim et al. 2009) in which cultural and linguistic material travels around the world to produce not global languages but rather global and translocal styles. These stylizations operate in a system of glocal distinctiveness, a system which functions not on shared linguistic norms but on stylistic commonalities and contrasts that pay equal attention to the local and the global. Youth all around the world have engaged Hip Hop and created their own HHNLVs and communicate with each other through the prism of style—a diversity of styles as *lingua franca*, if you will—to form a global style community. Unity within the Global Hip Hop Nation does more than merely tolerate diversity; it demands it.

I have argued that style is the central rubric through which to read Hip Hop Cultures. Blommaert (2003, p. 608), following Dell Hymes (1996) and Silverstein (1998), suggested that for a global level of analysis we need to "move from Languages to language varieties and repertoires" because "it is not abstract Language" that is globalized but rather "specific speech forms, genres, styles, and forms of literacy practice." This is certainly the case with Hip Hop. Its rhyming practices have altered poetic genres across the globe: Hip Hop artists in Japan have restructured Japanese in order to rhyme and flow (Condry 2006; Davis and Tsujimura 2008), and they, along with artists in Korea (Pennycook 2006, p. 128) and Italy (Androutsopoulos and Scholz 2003, pp. 474–475), have produced poetic structures such as the back-to-back chain rhymes and bridge rhymes similar to those described in Black American Hip Hop (Alim 2006).

Pushing Blommaert's argument even further, as we have seen in the case of Hip Hop, a language variety in the Hip Hop sense of "language as concept" does not refer to specific dialects or languages or styles *per se*; it refers to the variation between translocal style communities within the Global Hip Hop Nation style community. HHNLVs refers to the whole range of possibilities to an "approach to language" that relies equally upon Black America's continued role as a key frame of reference and on local approaches to language. The multiple indexicalities brought forth by such complex, multilayered uses of language necessitates a linguistic anthropology of globalization that gives a more central role to linguistic agency on the part of youth as they appropriate and remix the Hip Hop matrix. Youth around the world have created styles and languages that (re)mix dominant styles and languages in relation to those already present in their repertoires. It is the creation of these languages through agentive languaging that best describes globalization—not just language entering into and moving across various localities, but language created out of translocalities. This is a kind of agency that includes but goes beyond what Alessandro Duranti (2004) called "self-" or "ego-affirming" because Hip Hop artists are simultaneously using language to affirm a unique identity within a global community and shaping the kind of language that defines such community.

Finally, in theorizing language and globalization, I have tried to argue that language does not move around the world as a solo traveler. Rather, it travels within what I have called *mobile matrices*—sets of styles, aesthetics, knowledges, and ideologies that move in and out

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of localities and cross-cut modalities. As these matrices travel around the globe, people from diverse contexts engage them in their entirety but selectively adopt, adapt and/or reject varying aspects. This idea that languages-in-motion are traveling within mobile cultural matrices ironically requires linguistic anthropologists to pay even more attention to the local than ever before. For in order to read events (trans)locally, we will need more in-depth ethnographies, because globalization not only depends upon local arrangements but it also rearranges, reorders, and restructures those arrangements (Blommaert 2003; Alim and Pennycook 2006).

## Some Caveats: Extreme Locality, Cisheteropatriarchy, and a Path Forward

As I have shown, Hip Hop youth's global consciousness and their theories about the interrelatedness of style, language, and globalization offer us new ways of imagining our world, ways that ground current theories of global flows (Appadurai 1996). In-depth ethnographic explorations of Global Hip Hop Culture(s), and popular culture and mass-mediated and mass-circulated language more generally, can help us bring forth new understandings of linguistic and cultural processes in this global era. However, my more recent research on Hip Hop Culture in South Africa has led me to offer at least two important caveats to the ideas shared within this chapter. The first follows from the above discussion. No matter how languages, cultures, and ideologies move throughout the globe, I want to caution against a rush to emphasize "global linguistic flows" at the expense of the enduring *centrality* of the local. Second, even as we celebrate the truly remarkable global cultural flows of Hip Hop, I want to maintain a critical distance vis-à-vis the kinds of ideologies that "go global." It is imperative that we consider how localized regressive (read: exclusionary and harmful) ideologies are reified when enduring global systems such as patriarchy and homophobia, for example, come to be embedded in global youth cultures at least as deeply as the progressive, counterhegmonic language ideologies I have written about.

In considering the local, Quentin Williams (2016, 2018) has written about *extreme locality* in his ethnographies of Hip Hop cultural spaces in the "Coloured" townships of Cape Town, emphasizing how the performance of a rap battle and its locality are mutually constituted. He shows how local-spatial coordinates and non-local spatial elements are entextualized in the actual performance between two emcees. He also emphasizes the construction of the "extreme local" by focusing on how language varieties, styles, gestures, and audience interaction are variously referenced multilingually and incorporated into the performance, requiring a host of local knowledges to unpack, and therefore, appreciate. Specifically, he demonstrates how, through live performance, youth forge a local variety of HHNL that relies on the strategic and creative use of linguistic resources associated with English, Cape Afrikaans (*Kaaps* or Cape Afrikaans is a variety of Afrikaans spoken widely in the Cape Flats; see Afrikaaps below), the local street variety Sabela (an admixture of isiXhosa, Kaaps, Zulu, and non-verbal gang signs), and African American Language (AAL).

At least three zones of language ideological combat are relevant here. First, the hegemonic dominance of AAL in some global Hip Hop sites, including Cape Town, is being challenged in favor of more local varieties that privilege locally-relevant identities, politics, and epistemologies. Second, in a linguistic context where Cape Afrikaans is stigmatized across nearly all social domains related to power and upward mobility (from education to politics to the job market), "these youth registers challenge the supposed inferiority of this

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variety; its very use resists long-held stereotypes about Cape Afrikaans—and its speakers, mostly working-class Coloureds—as unintelligent, lazy, and criminal" (Williams 2016, p. 114). Third, in a context where the nation-state espouses multilingualism as the law of the land, yet hegemonic language ideologies continue to frame South Africans of Color as "illiterate" and their linguistic behavior as "disorderly" or "threatening," youth are creating an agentive multilingual citizenship through their local performances.

More recently, in collaborative work with South African scholars Quentin Williams, Adam Haupt, and Emile Jansen (Alim et al. 2021; Haupt et al. 2019), the local has emerged as central to the Afrikaaps language movement in Cape Town. In our theorizing of the *language–race–land complex* (Alim et al. 2021, p. 195)—the range of issues with respect to the co-constitution and refusal of the colonial logics of language, race, and land—the local emerged as central to the counternarrative of "Coloured" speakers of so-called "Afrikaans." I place this variety in quotes because *Afrikaaps* is a South African hiphopera that disrupts white settler colonial logics of language, race, and land through an interrogation and revision of white supremacist constructions of Afrikaans. This reinvention of language, race, and land frees the Afrikaans-speaking, Coloured community in Cape Town from oppressive, colonial, apartheid era logics and offers them new ways of envisioning their linguistic, racial, spatial, and political–economic futures in South Africa. What's relevant to this chapter is that the power of the movement is derived, in part, from the very specific role that the Cape played in shaping the language that artists and activists are reclaiming as Afrikaaps—and not just the Cape (Kaap) but Afrika as well (hence, Afrikaaps). While Afrikaaps Hip Hop artists and activists foreground Indigenous perspectives on land and ownership that disrupt white settler colonialist and white settler capitalist understandings of land as the property of humans to be bought and sold, their critical revision of white Afrikaner narratives of the linguistic history of Afrikaans relies centrally on the role of Indigenous people in the Cape who shaped the language's early development.

In other collaborative work with South African Hip Hop linguist Quentin Williams, we presented the first comparative analysis of the creative, improvised linguistic performances of gender, race, ethnicity, and sexuality by young men in freestyle rap battles and ciphers across two ethnographic sites: Los Angeles (United States) and Cape Town (South Africa; see Alim et al. 2018, 2020). Our comparative approach focuses on how young men in Project Blowed in Los Angeles (Leimert Park) and Club Stones in Cape Town (Kuilsriver) use improvised verbal art to position themselves and others within a local, critical circle of artists and within the broader discursive fields of race, gender and sexuality.

In our analyses, youth across these two sites are shown to rearticulate the intersecting dominant discourses of gender, sexuality, and the body by drawing on conceptions of race to provide momentary, creative benefits while further marginalizing the marginalized. Collectively, young men of color often challenge the dominance of Whiteness, while simultaneously celebrating and reifying particular kinds of Blackness/Colouredness at the expense of already marginalized gendered and sexualized bodies. These hegemonic practices reconstitute social divisions that benefit cisheteropatriarchy, an ideological system that naturalizes normative views of what it means to "look" and "act" like a "straight" man and marginalizes women, femininity, and all gender non-conforming bodies that challenge the gender binary. It is a system based on the exploitation and oppression of women and sexual minorities.

In terms of a linguistic anthropology of Hip Hop, specifically, and globalization more generally, we need more in-depth ethnographic explorations of Global Hip Hop Culture(s), a context in which team ethnographies could be used to maximal effect, in order to understand linguistic and cultural processes in this global era as well as comparative, multi-sited ones.

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